

ROYAL FITNESS CLUB

Complete Muscle Building & Transformation Manual

12 Chapters · 60+ Pages · 12-Week Program · Indian Athletes Edition

By Royal Fitness Club Expert Team

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CHAPTER 1 — MUSCLE BUILDING FUNDAMENTALS & SCIENCE

Muscle hypertrophy — the increase in muscle fibre cross-sectional area — occurs through three distinct but interconnected mechanisms. Understanding each mechanism allows you to structure training intelligently rather than randomly. Most gym-goers stimulate only one mechanism and wonder why they plateau after 3–6 months of consistent training.

- **Mechanical Tension:** The primary driver of hypertrophy. When a muscle fibre is placed under load through its full range of motion, the tension on the sarcomere activates mechanosensors (integrins, focal adhesion kinase) that trigger the mTOR signalling cascade — the master regulator of muscle protein synthesis. Heavier compound lifts, full ROM, and time under tension all maximise this mechanism.
- **Metabolic Stress:** The "pump" mechanism. Accumulation of lactate, hydrogen ions, and inorganic phosphate during high-rep training creates a cellular environment that increases anabolic hormone secretion locally, stimulates satellite cell activation, and produces cell swelling — all of which signal growth. Isolation exercises, moderate weight (12–20 reps), short rest periods (45–75 sec) maximise metabolic stress.
- **Muscle Damage:** Eccentric-dominant loading causes micro-tears in the muscle fibre and connective tissue. Repair via satellite cell fusion results in thicker, stronger fibres. Novel exercises, slow eccentrics (3–4 seconds on the lowering phase), and training through the lengthened position maximise muscle damage stimulus.

■ **Key Insight:** Train all three mechanisms weekly. Compound lifts for tension, isolation finishers for metabolic stress, slow eccentrics and new movements for muscle damage.

Fibre Type	Characteristics	Best Rep Range	Example
Type I	Endurance, fatigue-resistant, smaller	15–30 reps	Cable flies, leg press high-rep
Type II-A	Strength + endurance hybrid	8–15 reps	Bench press, squats, rows
Type II-X	Max power, fatigues quickly	1–6 reps	Deadlift, heavy OHP, sprints

Net muscle gain occurs only when Muscle Protein Synthesis (MPS) exceeds Muscle Protein Breakdown (MPB) over time. Training strongly elevates MPS for 24–48 hours post-session. Adequate protein intake (particularly leucine — the mTOR trigger) sustains this elevated synthetic rate. Sleep, caloric sufficiency, and low cortisol all suppress MPB. The athlete's job is to maximise MPS triggers while minimising MPB drivers.

Volume — defined as Sets × Reps × Load — is the primary driver of hypertrophy over time for intermediate and advanced athletes. Research by Krieger (2010) showed that 2–3 sets per exercise produce 40% greater hypertrophy than 1 set. Schoenfeld et al. (2017) found a dose-response relationship up to approximately 10–20 hard sets per muscle per week. Above this threshold, additional volume can impair recovery without proportional gain. For natural Indian athletes aged 20–40: 10–16 weekly hard sets per muscle group is the evidence-based starting point.

Training Level	Weekly Sets/Muscle	Frequency	Session Duration
Beginner (0–12 months)	6–10 sets	2×/week	45–55 min
Intermediate (1–3 years)	10–16 sets	2–3×/week	55–70 min
Advanced (3+ years)	14–22 sets	2–4×/week	60–80 min

CHAPTER 2 — ANABOLIC HORMONES & NATURAL OPTIMISATION

Your hormonal environment sets the ceiling for natural muscle-building potential. Testosterone, Growth Hormone (GH), IGF-1, and Insulin work in concert to regulate protein synthesis, satellite cell activation, fat oxidation, and glycogen storage. Every lifestyle choice either supports or suppresses these hormones — often more powerfully than any supplement.

Normal male testosterone range in India: 300–1000 ng/dL. Testosterone binds to androgen receptors (AR) in muscle cells, activating gene transcription for contractile proteins (actin, myosin). Higher AR density = better response to the same testosterone level. AR density is trainable — resistance training increases AR expression by 25–50% in trained muscle over 12 weeks.

- Compound lifts (squat, deadlift, bench) trigger the largest acute testosterone spike.
- Sleep 7.5–9h: 60–70% of daily T is produced during slow-wave sleep. One week of 5h nights reduces T by 10–15%.
- Body fat 10–18%: Excess adipose aromatises T to oestrogen via aromatase enzyme.
- Zinc & Vitamin D3: Rate-limiting cofactors for T synthesis. Common deficiencies in India due to indoor lifestyles.
- Stress management: Cortisol and testosterone compete for the same precursor (pregnenolone). Chronic stress blunts T.

GH is released in pulses from the anterior pituitary — largest pulse occurring during Stage 3 NREM sleep. GH stimulates the liver to produce IGF-1, which activates the PI3K/Akt/mTOR pathway — the same pathway activated by resistance training. This synergy means athletes who sleep well and train hard experience multiplicative (not additive) anabolic effects.

Factor	Effect on GH/IGF-1	Practical Action
Deep sleep (8h)	↑↑↑ GH pulse amplitude	Prioritise dark room, same bedtime
High-intensity exercise	↑↑ acute GH release	Include compound heavy sets
16h fast	↑↑ GH (3–5× baseline)	Intermittent fasting optional
Body fat >25%	↓↓ GH pulse	Prioritise fat loss first
Protein intake adequate	↑ IGF-1 production	Maintain 1.8–2.2g/kg/day

Insulin drives amino acids and glucose into muscle cells, inhibits muscle protein breakdown, and stimulates glycogen synthesis. The key is timing: spike insulin around training when muscles are insulin-sensitive; manage it the rest of the day to prevent fat storage. Post-workout: rice + dal + chicken is near-perfect — fast carbs (rice) spike insulin, complete protein (chicken) saturates MPS, slow protein (dal) extends it.

Chronic cortisol elevation activates the ubiquitin-proteasome pathway (muscle breakdown), inhibits testosterone synthesis, impairs sleep quality, and promotes visceral fat. Training sessions over 75 minutes consistently elevate cortisol without proportional anabolic benefit. Keep sessions focused and under 75 minutes; manage life stress actively.

- Ashwagandha KSM-66 (600mg/day): Reduces cortisol by 27.9% in peer-reviewed trial (Chandrasekhar et al., 2012).
- Post-workout carbohydrate: blunts cortisol spike by 20–30% — eat your post-workout carbs.
- Meditation (10 min/day): Measurably reduces baseline cortisol within 4 weeks of consistent practice.
- Sleep 7.5–9h: Sleep deprivation is the fastest way to chronically elevate cortisol.

CHAPTER 3 — PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD — THE SCIENCE OF PROGRESS

Progressive overload is the single most important training principle. Without systematically increasing demand on muscle tissue, the body has no stimulus to adapt. Muscles grow only when challenged beyond their current capacity — and they must be repeatedly re-challenged as they adapt. Progressive overload is not just "add weight every week" — it encompasses 10 distinct methods.

Method	How to Apply	Best For	Frequency
Add weight	Increase load when reps hit top of range with RIR≥2	Compound lifts	Every 1–2 weeks
Add reps	Same weight, more reps each session	Accessory work	Weekly
Add sets	Gradually increase weekly volume (+1 set/muscle/week)	All levels	Monthly
Reduce rest	Shorten rest by 10sec per session	Metabolic goals	Weekly
Slow eccentric	Add 1 sec to lowering phase	Hypertrophy focus	Monthly
Increase ROM	Work through greater joint range	Muscle length emphasis	Monthly
Better technique	Stricter form = greater target activation	All levels	Always
Increase frequency	Train muscle 2×/wk → 3×/wk	Intermediate plateaus	Phase change
Density blocks	More total work in same time window	Advanced	Phase change
Harder variation	Progress to more challenging exercise	All levels	Phase change

Periodisation is the systematic variation of training variables (volume, intensity, frequency) to maximise long-term adaptation while managing fatigue. Without periodisation, fatigue accumulates faster than fitness — causing overtraining, plateau, and injury. Three primary models serve different athletes and goals.

Model	Structure	Best For	Evidence
Linear (LP)	Volume ↓, intensity ↑ week by week	Beginners 0–12 months	Strong
Daily Undulating (DUP)	Different rep ranges on different days	Intermediate 1–4 years	Very strong
Block Periodisation	Accumulation → Intensification → Realisation	Advanced 4+ years	Strong

■ For Indian athletes aged 18–35 seeking muscle gain: Daily Undulating Periodisation in a Push/Pull/Legs split is the most evidence-backed natural hypertrophy approach.

A deload is a planned reduction in training volume/intensity for 1 week every 4–8 weeks of hard training. Its purpose is to dissipate accumulated systemic fatigue, allowing the nervous system to fully express adaptations built during the preceding block. Post-deload personal records (PRs) are the rule, not the exception, when deloads are correctly timed.

Deload Type	Volume Change	Intensity Change	Best Use
Volume deload	–40–60% sets	Same weight	Accumulated volume fatigue

Intensity deload	Same sets	–15–20% weight	Joint/tendon soreness
Full deload	–50% both	–20% weight	After competition/peaking
Active recovery	Light cardio/mobility	Very low	Overreaching/illness

CHAPTER 4 — NUTRITION BLUEPRINTS FOR MAXIMUM MUSCLE GROWTH

Goal	Calorie Target	Protein	Carbohydrates	Fats
Lean Bulk	TDEE + 250–350 kcal	2.0–2.2g/kg	4–5g/kg	0.8–1.0g/kg
Fat Loss	TDEE – 350–500 kcal	2.2–2.5g/kg	2–3g/kg	0.7–0.9g/kg
Recomposition	TDEE ± 0–100 kcal	1.8–2.2g/kg	3–4g/kg	0.8–1.0g/kg

Protein is the only macro that directly builds muscle tissue. The ISSN (2017) consensus: 1.6–2.2g/kg/day is optimal for muscle protein synthesis. For athletes in a caloric deficit (cutting), increase to 2.2–2.5g/kg to protect muscle mass. Leucine is the key amino acid triggering mTOR — each meal should contain ≥3g leucine (~30–35g complete protein) to maximally activate muscle protein synthesis. Spreading protein across 4–5 meals is superior to 2–3 large servings.

Carbohydrates are the primary fuel for high-intensity resistance training. Muscle glycogen is the substrate for intense efforts — depleted glycogen directly impairs training performance, volume capacity, and recovery speed. Low-carb diets reduce training performance by 7–15% in resistance-trained athletes. For Indian athletes: rice, roti, oats, and fruit are excellent, culturally appropriate carbohydrate sources. Fear of carbs is one of the most productivity-destroying nutrition myths.

Dietary fat is essential for testosterone production (cholesterol is the precursor), fat-soluble vitamin absorption, joint lubrication, and cell membrane integrity. Target 20–30% of total calories from fat, with emphasis on unsaturated sources (nuts, seeds, ghee, fatty fish) and adequate saturated fat (eggs, full-fat dairy) for hormone synthesis. Trans fats (vanaspati, processed foods) directly suppress testosterone and impair cardiovascular health — eliminate them.

■ *Ghee (desi ghee) in moderate amounts is not the villain it was once portrayed as. It is rich in butyrate, supports gut health, and provides fat-soluble vitamins. 1–2 tsp daily is beneficial for Indian athletes.*

Timing	What to Eat	Purpose
Pre-workout (60–90 min)	40–60g carbs + 25g protein + minimal fat	Max glycogen, raise blood amino acids
Post-workout (<45 min)	50–80g fast carbs + 30–40g fast protein	Insulin spike, suppress MPB
Pre-sleep	30–40g slow protein (paneer, dahi, eggs)	Sustain MPS for 7h during sleep
Rest days	Maintain protein; slightly reduce carbs	Recovery, maintain anabolic state

CHAPTER 5 — HIGH-PROTEIN INDIAN FOOD & MEAL TIMING

Food	Serving	Protein	Calories	Notes
Chicken breast	100g cooked	31g	165 kcal	Complete protein, BV 79
Eggs (whole)	1 large	6g	78 kcal	Best BV (100), complete amino profile
Paneer	100g	18g	265 kcal	Casein-rich, slow-digesting
Moong dal (cooked)	150g	10g	170 kcal	Leucine-rich, affordable
Chana dal	150g	12g	200 kcal	High fibre + protein
Greek yogurt (dahi)	200g	14g	140 kcal	Probiotics + casein
Soya chunks (dry)	50g	25g	175 kcal	Complete plant protein
Fish (rohu)	100g	22g	120 kcal	Omega-3 rich, anabolic
Chicken egg whites	3 large	10g	50 kcal	Near-zero fat, fast absorbing
Low-fat cottage cheese	100g	11g	98 kcal	Slow-release, good at night
Whey protein	1 scoop (30g)	24g	120 kcal	Fast-absorbing, post-workout ideal
Rajma (cooked)	150g	8g	185 kcal	Combine with rice for complete protein
Milk (full-fat)	250ml	8g	150 kcal	Casein + whey natural combination
Chicken thigh	100g	26g	210 kcal	More flavour, slightly higher fat
Tuna (canned)	100g	26g	116 kcal	Very affordable, complete protein

Meal	Foods	Protein	Cost
Breakfast	3 eggs + 2 roti + glass of milk	28g	~₹30
Mid-Morning	Dahi + banana	10g	~₹20
Lunch	100g soya chunks + 200g rice + sabzi	32g	~₹40
Evening	Chana + roasted makhana	15g	~₹25
Dinner	100g chicken + dal + 2 roti	40g	~₹70
Total		125g protein	~₹185

■ *Indian protein sources are among the most cost-effective in the world. Soya chunks provide 25g protein per 50g dry weight at approximately ₹15–20 — cheaper than most supplements per gram of protein.*

Food	Serving	Carbs	GI	Best Timing
White rice	150g cooked	45g	73 (High)	Post-workout
Brown rice	150g cooked	40g	50 (Med)	Any meal
Chapati (wheat)	1 medium (35g)	18g	55 (Med)	Any meal

Oats	80g dry	55g	55 (Med)	Breakfast / pre-workout
Banana	1 medium	27g	51 (Med)	Pre/post workout
Sweet potato	150g cooked	35g	44 (Low)	Pre-workout / dinner
Quinoa	150g cooked	34g	53 (Med)	Lunch / dinner

CHAPTER 6 — SUPPLEMENT GUIDE — RANKED BY EVIDENCE

Supplement	Dose	Timing	Mechanism	Evidence Grade
Creatine Monohydrate	5g/day	Any time (consistency matters)	Replenishes PCr, cellular hydration	A (500+ RCTs)
Whey Protein	25–50g/day	Post-workout priority	High leucine, fast absorption	A
Caffeine	3–6mg/kg	45 min pre-workout	Adenosine antagonism, CNS stimulation	A
Vitamin D3	2000–5000 IU/day	With a fatty meal	Testosterone cofactor, bone health	A
Magnesium Glycinate	300–400mg	Before bed	Sleep quality, testosterone, >300 enzymes	A

Supplement	Dose	Benefit	Notes
Beta-Alanine	3.2g/day	Reduces fatigue in 8–15 rep range	Tingling (paresthesia) is harmless
Citrulline Malate	6–8g pre	Better pump, reduces DOMS by ~40%	Underrated, very affordable
Ashwagandha KSM-66	600mg/day	↓ Cortisol 28%, ↑ T 15–17%	Indian adaptogen — widely available
Omega-3 Fish Oil	3g EPA+DHA	Reduces inflammation, faster recovery	Vegans: algae-based alternative
Zinc	15–30mg/day	Testosterone synthesis cofactor	Supplement only if deficient (test first)
Collagen + Vit C	15g + 500mg pre-workout	Tendon/ligament synthesis	Take 60 min before training

- BCAAs (if protein adequate): Isolated BCAAs add nothing when total daily protein is sufficient (1.8g/kg+).
- Most commercial "testosterone boosters": Studies show negligible effect on actual serum testosterone.
- Weight gainers: 90% simple carbohydrates. Better to eat rice. Same effect, 10× cheaper.
- Glutamine: Effective post-surgery. Useless for healthy, adequately-nourished athletes.
- CLA: Modest fat loss (–0.1kg/week maximum). Not worth the cost or marketing claims.
- Nitric oxide boosters (most): Citrulline (Tier 2) is the exception — most others are ineffective.

■ **Budget Power Stack (■1,500/month): Creatine monohydrate ■400 + Vitamin D3 ■150 + Magnesium ■200 + Ashwagandha ■250 + Whey protein from food = outperforms 90% of expensive stacks.**

CHAPTER 7 — RECOVERY, SLEEP & CORTISOL MANAGEMENT

Muscle tissue is built during sleep, not during training. Stage 3 NREM (deep sleep) is when 60–70% of daily Growth Hormone is released — the pulse responsible for tissue repair, protein synthesis, and fat mobilisation. REM sleep consolidates motor learning, making new movement patterns automatic. Both stages are essential for athletes.

Sleep Variable	Optimal	When Compromised	Fix
Duration	7.5–9 hours	–23% T, –31% IGF-1 at 6h	Prioritise sleep over morning cardio
Room temp	16–19°C	>22°C disrupts deep sleep	Fan / AC + blackout curtains
Light	Complete darkness	Blue light delays melatonin 90 min	No screens 60 min before bed
Consistency	±30 min same time	Irregular = 25% worse quality	Set sleep/wake alarms
Pre-sleep food	Protein, low sugar	High sugar disrupts NREM stage 3	Paneer/dahi 90 min before bed

- Contrast showers (3 min hot / 1 min cold × 3 cycles): Reduces DOMS by 30–40%, improves parasympathetic tone.
- Light walking (20–30 min on rest days): Promotes blood flow and nutrient delivery without adding training stress.
- Foam rolling / myofascial release: Reduces perceived soreness and improves ROM acutely. 30–60 sec per muscle.
- Pranayama — 4-7-8 breathing: Activates parasympathetic nervous system, reduces cortisol measurably within 10 minutes.
- Epsom salt bath (optional): Transdermal magnesium absorption + heat-induced muscle relaxation.

HRV is the variation in time between consecutive heartbeats — a direct measure of autonomic nervous system balance. High HRV = good recovery, parasympathetic dominance. Low HRV = accumulated fatigue, sympathetic overload. Measure HRV with a fitness tracker (Garmin, Whoop, or free apps like Elite HRV) first thing every morning. If HRV is trending down across 3+ days: reduce volume by 30%, prioritise sleep, increase food intake.

CHAPTER 8 — ADVANCED TRAINING TECHNIQUES

Advanced training techniques are tools for intermediate and advanced athletes (12+ months) who have plateaued on straight-set programming. Beginners extract more benefit from adding weight and reps to basic movements. These techniques extend training volume beyond what straight sets allow — increasing mechanical tension and metabolic stress in the same or less time.

Technique	Mechanism	Best Exercises	When to Use
Drop sets	Extends time under tension past failure	Curls, laterals, pushdowns	Final 1–2 sets per session
Supersets (antagonist)	Reciprocal inhibition potentiation	Bi/Tri, Back/Chest pairs	Throughout workout
Giant sets	Metabolic overload, time efficiency	3–4 isolation exercises	Finisher at end of workout
Cluster sets	High load at sub-maximal fatigue	Deadlift, squat, bench	Intensification phases
Rest-pause	Extend set past normal failure	Any isolation exercise	Advanced, intermediate+
Mechanical drop	Biomechanical advantage as fatigue rises	DB lateral → front raise	Advanced athletes
Pre-exhaustion	Fatigue prime mover via isolation first	Cable fly → bench press	Chest specialisation
Blood flow restriction	Metabolic stress at low loads	Arms, calves	Injury rehab or volume add

■ **Rule of Thumb:** *Never use advanced techniques as a substitute for progressive overload on the basics. Fancy techniques on top of a weak foundation produce minimal results.*

CHAPTER 9 — FULL 12-WEEK ANABOLIC TRANSFORMATION PROGRAM

This 12-week program is built on a Push/Pull/Legs (PPL) split running 5–6 days per week, with planned deload weeks and three progressive phases. The program is appropriate for intermediate athletes (12+ months consistent training) with solid technique on all compound movements. Beginners should run a linear 3-day full-body programme for the first 6 months before transitioning to PPL.

Phase	Weeks	Focus	Rep Ranges	Sets/Muscle/Week	RIR Target
Accumulation	1–4	Build volume tolerance	10–15	10–14	3–4
Intensification	5–8	Strength + hypertrophy	6–10	14–18	1–2
Deload	9	Recovery	Any	50% reduction	4–5
Peaking	10–12	Max intensity	4–8	16–20	0–1

Day	Session	Muscles Trained	Duration
Monday	Push A — Chest dominant	Chest, front delts, triceps	60–70 min
Tuesday	Pull A — Back width	Lats, upper back, rear delts, biceps	65–75 min
Wednesday	Legs A — Quad dominant	Quads, hamstrings, glutes, calves	70–80 min
Thursday	Push B — Shoulder dominant	Delts, chest secondary, triceps	55–65 min
Friday	Pull B — Back thickness + Arms	Mid/lower back, biceps + triceps	60–70 min
Saturday	Legs B — Posterior chain	Hamstrings, glutes, quad secondary	65–75 min
Sunday	Rest / Active Recovery	Walking, mobility, pranayama	20–30 min

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest	Tempo	Notes
A1	Barbell Bench Press	4	12	2 min	3-0-1	Controlled descent
A2	Incline DB Press	3	12	90s	3-0-1	Full stretch at bottom
B1	Cable Crossover (low)	3	15	60s	2-1-1	Squeeze at peak
C1	Seated DB OHP	4	12	90s	3-0-1	Full ROM, no arch
C2	Cable Lateral Raise	4	15	60s	2-1-1	Elbow height
D1	Tricep Pushdown (rope)	3	15	60s	2-1-1	Lock out fully
D2	Overhead Tricep Ext.	3	12	60s	3-0-1	Full stretch

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest	Notes
A1	Pull-ups / Lat Pulldown	4	10–12	2 min	Full hang to full flex

A2	Barbell / DB Row	4	10	90s	Chest supported reduces cheating
B1	Seated Cable Row (wide)	3	12	90s	Drive elbows back, squeeze
B2	Face Pull (rope)	4	15	60s	External rotation at end
C1	Rear Delt Fly (cable)	3	15	60s	Elbow-out, squeeze at rear
D1	Barbell Curl	3	12	60s	Full ROM, no swing
D2	Incline DB Curl	3	12	60s	Lengthened bicep position

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest	Notes
A1	Barbell Back Squat	4	10	2.5 min	Hip crease below parallel
A2	Romanian Deadlift	3	12	2 min	Feel hamstring stretch at bottom
B1	Leg Press	4	15	90s	Full ROM, no knee cave
B2	Leg Curl (seated)	4	12	90s	Pause at peak flex
C1	Bulgarian Split Squat	3	12/leg	90s	Front foot out, torso upright
D1	Standing Calf Raise	5	15	60s	Full ROM — heel drop essential

CHAPTER 10 — COMPLETE WEEKLY WORKOUT LIBRARY

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Notes
A1	Seated Barbell OHP	4	8–10	Heavy. Full lock-out at top.
A2	DB Arnold Press	3	12	Rotation maximises all three delt heads
B1	DB Lateral Raise	5	15	5 sets — delts respond to volume
B2	Cable Upright Row	3	12	Elbows flare above shoulders
C1	Incline DB Press	4	12	Shoulder-width grip, full stretch
D1	Skull Crushers	4	12	EZ bar, controlled descent
D2	Close-Grip Bench Press	3	10	Compound tricep finisher

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Notes
A1	Barbell Deadlift (conventional)	4	6	King of mass. Brace hard.
A2	T-Bar Row / Chest-Supported Row	4	10	Middle back thickness
B1	Single-Arm DB Row	3	12	Full stretch at bottom, full retraction
B2	Straight-Arm Lat Pulldown	3	15	Isolates lats — no elbow bend
C1	EZ Bar Curl	4	12	Supinated at top, full stretch at bottom
C2	Hammer Curl	3	12	Brachialis + brachioradialis
D1	Tricep Pushdown (straight bar)	4	15	Keep elbows pinned
D2	Single-Arm Overhead Ext.	3	12	Long head emphasis

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Notes
A1	Romanian Deadlift	4	10	Primary hamstring/glute builder
A2	Leg Curl (lying)	4	12	Pause 1 sec at peak flexion
B1	Hip Thrust (barbell)	4	12	Glute maximiser — drive hips to ceiling
B2	Sumo Deadlift or Leg Press	3	12	High-and-wide foot position
C1	Walking Lunges	3	20 steps	Quad + glute combination
C2	Adductor Machine	3	15	Inner thigh stability
D1	Seated Calf Raise	5	15	Soleus — needs 130°+ knee bend to activate

In weeks 5–8, apply the following modifications to all sessions from the Accumulation phase: — Reduce all rep ranges by 3–4 reps (e.g., 12 reps → 8–9 reps) — Increase load by 7.5–12.5% from week 4 end weights — Increase rest periods by 30 seconds for compound lifts — Reduce isolation exercise volume by 1 set each

— Add 1 heavy back-off set at end of each compound movement

Post-deload peaking phase focuses on maximising intensity (RIR 0–1) while managing volume to avoid accumulating excessive fatigue. — Reduce rep ranges further (4–8 reps on main compounds) — Work at 85–92% of 1RM on key lifts — Focus on compound movements; reduce isolation work — Take body measurements and progress photos at weeks 4, 8, and 12 — Use week 12 weights as new baseline for next programme cycle

CHAPTER 11 — INDIAN DIET TEMPLATES & MACRO BLUEPRINTS

Meal	Time	Foods	P	C	F	kcal
Breakfast	7:30 AM	4 eggs + 2 roti + dahi (200g)	36g	42g	18g	476
Mid-Morning	10:30 AM	Banana + 20 almonds + 200ml milk	10g	38g	12g	298
Lunch	1:00 PM	150g chicken + 200g rice + dal + sabzi	46g	72g	10g	562
Pre-WO	4:00 PM	Oats 80g + 1 banana + whey 25g	32g	60g	6g	426
Post-WO	7:00 PM	150g chicken + 180g rice + salad	46g	65g	8g	520
Dinner	9:30 PM	100g paneer + 2 roti + sabzi + dahi	28g	32g	14g	362

Total: 2,644 kcal | 198g P | 309g C | 68g F

Meal	Time	Foods	P	C	F	kcal
Breakfast	7:00 AM	3 egg whites + 1 egg + 1 roti + green tea	23g	18g	7g	227
Lunch	12:30 PM	130g chicken + 100g rice + dal + sabzi	36g	42g	7g	375
Evening	4:30 PM	Greek dahi 200g + cucumber + 10 almonds	16g	12g	9g	189
Dinner	7:30 PM	100g paneer + sabzi + 1 roti + salad	22g	22g	12g	284
Pre-Sleep	9:30 PM	200ml warm milk + 5 walnuts	10g	12g	9g	169

Total: 1,244 kcal sample — scale portions to reach 1,600–1,800 kcal target

Meal	Time	Foods	P	C	F	kcal
Breakfast	7:30 AM	Paneer bhurji 200g + 3 roti + dahi 150g	44g	48g	22g	572
Mid-Morning	10:30 AM	Soya chunks (50g dry) curry + 100g rice	30g	42g	5g	333
Lunch	1:00 PM	Moong dal 200g + 200g rice + sabzi	28g	82g	7g	507
Pre-WO	4:00 PM	Whey 30g + banana + oats 60g	30g	58g	5g	401
Post-WO	7:00 PM	Paneer 150g + 200g rice + salad	32g	65g	14g	518
Dinner	9:30 PM	Chana dal 200g + 2 roti + curd	28g	55g	10g	426

Total: 2,757 kcal | 192g P | 350g C | 63g F — scale rice/roti to reach 3,000 kcal

Meal	Time	Foods	P	C	F	kcal
Breakfast	8:00 AM	4 eggs fried in ghee + spinach sauté	24g	3g	28g	368
Lunch	1:00 PM	200g chicken thigh + greens + avocado	44g	8g	32g	492
Evening	4:30 PM	50g walnuts + 30g paneer	10g	4g	22g	254

Dinner	7:30 PM	200g mutton + cauliflower sabzi + raita	48g	12g	30g	506
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Total: 1,620 kcal sample — add fat sources (ghee, coconut oil, nuts) to reach 2,200 kcal

CHAPTER 12 — INJURY PREVENTION, JOINT HEALTH & LONGEVITY

The athlete who trains consistently for 5 years will always outperform the athlete who trains harder for 2 years before getting injured. Injury prevention is not passive maintenance — it is an active, ongoing investment in the machinery that allows you to train. Most injuries in Indian gym athletes are predictable failures of progressive overload, technique, or recovery management.

Injury	Root Cause	Prevention	If It Occurs
Lower back pain	Poor hip hinge, excessive lumbar loading	Hip hinge drills, RDL technique, brace always	Reduce load, McGill Big 3 rehab
Rotator cuff strain	Internal rotation imbalance, poor shoulder mechanics	Face pulls, external rotation 3x20 daily, scapular work	Reduce pressing, add rotator cuff rehab
Patellar knee pain	Quad dominance, poor ankle mobility	Mobility work, foam rolling IT band, ankle mobility	Reduce squats, reduce depth temporarily
Bicep tendinopathy	Excessive curl load with poor technique	Eccentric curls, reduce load	Ice, reduce supinated grip work
Tennis elbow	Excessive grip-heavy exercises	Wrist extensor stretches, reduce grip volume	Ice, 2-week deload from pulling

Duration	Activity	Purpose
3 min	Light cardio (skip rope / bike)	Raise core temperature 1–2°C
2 min	Dynamic stretching (leg swings, arm circles)	Mobilise joints through ROM
2 min	Activation (glute bridges, band work)	Prime target muscles
3–4 min	Progressive warm-up sets (40% / 60% / 80%)	Neural preparation for working weights

Nutrient	Dose	Source	Primary Benefit
Collagen peptides	15–20g/day	Supplement	Tendon and cartilage repair
Omega-3 (EPA+DHA)	3g/day	Fish oil / fatty fish	Reduce joint inflammation
Vitamin C	500–1000mg/day	Amla, guava, supplement	Collagen synthesis cofactor
Curcumin + piperine	500–1000mg/day	Haldi + black pepper	Potent anti-inflammatory
Glucosamine	1500mg/day	Supplement	Moderate evidence for joint comfort

■ **Lifetime Rule: A 10% reduction in training ego produces a 1000% better outcome across a 10-year athletic career. Train hard, recover harder, and stay injury-free above all else.**

APPENDIX A — GLOSSARY OF KEY TERMS

1RM (One-Rep Max): The maximum weight you can lift for exactly one repetition with full control.

Anabolic: Describes a state or process that promotes tissue building, especially muscle.

Catabolism: The breakdown of muscle tissue for energy — opposite of anabolism.

DOMS: Delayed Onset Muscle Soreness — muscle soreness 24–72h post-training. Normal adaptation signal.

FFMI (Fat-Free Mass Index): A body composition metric accounting for lean mass relative to height. Max natural FFMI $\approx$ 25.

GH (Growth Hormone): Pituitary hormone that stimulates IGF-1 production, fat oxidation, and tissue repair.

Hypertrophy: Increase in muscle fibre size (cross-sectional area) — the primary goal of bodybuilding.

IGF-1: Insulin-like Growth Factor 1 — produced in the liver, mediates most of GH's anabolic effects.

mTOR: Mammalian Target of Rapamycin — the master regulator of muscle protein synthesis. Activated by leucine and mechanical tension.

MPS (Muscle Protein Synthesis): The rate of protein incorporation into muscle tissue. Training and leucine are the primary drivers.

MPB (Muscle Protein Breakdown): The rate of muscle protein degradation. Elevated by cortisol, fasting, and insufficient protein.

PCr (Phosphocreatine): The primary energy currency for maximal efforts lasting 1–10 seconds. Replenished by creatine supplementation.

Progressive Overload: The systematic increase of training demands over time to force continued adaptation.

RIR (Reps In Reserve): The number of reps remaining before technical failure. RIR 2 = could do 2 more reps.

Satellite Cells: Muscle stem cells that activate upon damage to repair and grow muscle fibres by donating nuclei.

TDEE (Total Daily Energy Expenditure): Total calories burned in a day including BMR + activity. Your calorie maintenance level.

Time Under Tension: Total duration a muscle is under load during a set. Influences mechanical tension and metabolic stress.

APPENDIX B — FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

A: Beginners typically notice strength gains within 2 weeks (neural adaptations) and visible muscle changes within 8–12 weeks of consistent training + adequate nutrition. Body fat reduction becomes visible at approximately 1–1.5kg/month of consistent deficit.

A: Fasted cardio burns slightly more fat in the session but produces equivalent fat loss to fed training over 24 hours (total daily energy balance determines fat loss, not session-level substrate utilisation). For resistance training specifically: training in a fed state preserves more muscle. Eat before lifting.

A: Yes. Creatine monohydrate is the most extensively studied supplement in history (500+ RCTs over 30 years). No evidence of harm in healthy athletes at 3–5g/day. The "creatine damages kidneys" myth applies only to individuals with pre-existing kidney disease.

A: The old "30g limit" is a myth. The body absorbs all protein eaten — the question is the rate of MPS stimulation. Each meal needs ≥ 3 g leucine (≈ 30 g complete protein) to maximally trigger mTOR. Additional protein at a meal is still used — absorbed more slowly and used for non-muscle functions.

A: Absolutely. Indian food provides excellent complete protein: eggs, chicken, paneer, soya chunks, and dal are all superior to or equivalent to whey for building muscle when consumed in sufficient quantity. Whey is convenient, not essential.

A: Yes, with modifications. Women build muscle via identical mechanisms to men. Rep ranges, volume, and progressive overload principles apply identically. Women should use the same programme structure with appropriate loads. The primary adjustment: women benefit from slightly higher rep ranges (10–15 primary) and may recover faster, enabling higher frequency.

A: Yes — especially for beginners, detrained athletes, and those with higher body fat ($>20\%$ for men, $>28\%$ for women). This "body recomposition" slows as athletes become more trained and leaner. At TDEE with high protein (2.2g/kg), trained athletes can slowly recomp. True simultaneous mass gain + fat loss at an advanced level requires very precise execution.

A: Persistent fatigue despite adequate sleep, declining performance across multiple sessions, mood changes (irritability, apathy), elevated resting heart rate, sleep disturbances, and recurring minor injuries. True overtraining is rare — most athletes experience "overreaching" which resolves with 1–2 weeks of reduced volume. Address with deload, increased food, and sleep before reducing training long-term.

ROYAL FITNESS CLUB

Your transformation starts today. Apply one principle from each chapter this week.

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FULL 12-WEEK PROGRAM — WEEK-BY-WEEK PROGRESSIVE TARGETS

The table below shows progressive weight/rep targets for the five primary compound movements across all 12 weeks. These are guide targets for a 75kg intermediate male with approximately 18 months training experience. Adjust starting weights based on your own current capability — the progression rates are the key reference, not the absolute numbers. Always prioritise technique over hitting the target weight. If form breaks, hold the weight and increase reps instead.

Week	Phase	Squat (kg)	Bench (kg)	Deadlift (kg)	OHP (kg)	Row (kg)	RIR
1	Accumulation	80×12	65×12	100×12	50×12	60×12	3–4
2	Accumulation	82.5×12	67.5×12	102.5×12	52.5×12	62.5×12	3–4
3	Accumulation	85×11	70×11	105×11	55×11	65×11	2–3
4	Accumulation	87.5×10	72.5×10	107.5×10	57.5×10	67.5×10	2–3
5	Intensification	90×8	75×8	110×8	60×8	70×8	2
6	Intensification	92.5×8	77.5×8	112.5×8	62.5×8	72.5×8	1–2
7	Intensification	95×7	80×7	115×7	65×7	75×7	1–2
8	Intensification	97.5×6	82.5×6	117.5×6	67.5×6	77.5×6	1
9	DELOAD	80×10	65×10	100×10	50×10	62.5×10	4–5
10	Peaking	100×5	85×5	120×5	70×5	80×5	1
11	Peaking	105×4	87.5×4	125×4	72.5×4	82.5×4	0–1
12	Peaking (Test)	110×3	90×3	130×3	75×3	85×3	0

■ *Week 12 is your testing week — attempt new PBs on each primary lift. This data becomes the baseline for your next training cycle.*

Phase	Weeks	Calorie Adjustment	Protein	Carb Strategy	Notes
Accumulation	1–4	TDEE + 200 kcal	2.0g/kg	Higher carbs on training days	Build volume tolerance
Intensification	5–8	TDEE + 300 kcal	2.1g/kg	Consistent high carbs daily	Support heavier loads
Deload	9	TDEE or slight deficit	2.2g/kg	Moderate carbs	Prioritise sleep + recovery
Peaking	10–12	TDEE + 150 kcal	2.2g/kg	Carb load 24h pre-test day	Feel strong and sharp

EXERCISE TECHNIQUE MASTER GUIDE

The back squat is the most effective lower body mass builder in existence. It simultaneously loads the quadriceps, hamstrings, glutes, erector spinae, and core — making it the most time-efficient exercise for total lower body development. Poor squat technique is the number one cause of lower back injury in Indian gym athletes.

- Setup: Bar on upper traps (high bar) or rear delts (low bar). Feet shoulder-width or slightly wider. Toes pointed 15–30° outward.
- Brace: Take a big breath, brace your core as if taking a punch (360° pressure). This is your intra-abdominal pressure — your natural weightlifting belt.
- Descent: Initiate by pushing knees out and sitting between your heels. Hip crease must go below the top of the kneecap (parallel minimum).
- Ascent: Drive through the entire foot. Think "push the floor away." Chest up, knees tracking over toes throughout.
- Common errors: Forward lean (weak quads/ankles), knees caving (weak glutes/abductors), heel rising (tight ankles — fix with elevated heels temporarily).

The deadlift builds more total muscle mass than any other exercise. It trains the entire posterior chain (hamstrings, glutes, erector spinae, traps, lats) plus the quadriceps and core. The learning curve is steep but the payoff is unparalleled — no other single exercise builds as much total-body density and strength.

- Setup: Bar over mid-foot (touching or 2cm from shins). Hip-width stance. Grip just outside legs. Hip hinge to reach bar — do not squat down to it.
 - Back: Spine neutral. Chest up, lats tight (think "protect your armpits"). Tension throughout before the bar leaves the floor.
 - Pull: Leg drive first — push floor away. Bar stays in contact with legs throughout the entire lift.
 - Lockout: Drive hips forward at the top. Stand fully tall. Do not hyperextend the lower back.
 - Common errors: Rounded lower back (too heavy/weak posterior chain), bar swinging away from body (lost lat tension), jerking (missed bracing).
-
- Setup: Eyes under the bar. Grip 1.5–2× shoulder width. Retract and depress shoulder blades into the bench — create a stable base.
 - Arch: Maintain a natural lower back arch — this is structural, not performance-enhancing cheating. Feet flat on the floor.
 - Descent: Bar travels in a slight arc (not straight down). Touch chest at the lower pec line (around nipple level) — not neck.
 - Press: Drive bar back and slightly up. Think "bend the bar" to engage lats. Maintain wrist stack over elbows throughout.
 - Common errors: Shoulder pain (flared elbows — tuck to 45–60°), bar bouncing off chest, loss of shoulder blade retraction during set.

- Setup: Barbell on upper chest. Grip just outside shoulder width. Elbows slightly in front of bar at start.
- Press: Drive bar straight up and slightly back as it clears the head. Lock out fully — do not stop short.
- Core: Actively brace throughout. No lumbar hyperextension — if you need to excessively lean back, the weight is too heavy.
- Common errors: Bar path going forward (weak upper back), lower back hyperextension, partial reps (not locking out).

■ ***Perfect technique on compound lifts is worth 6–12 months of faster progress. Film yourself from the side on your first few sessions with each movement. Technique errors are invisible to the lifter.***

BODY MEASUREMENT & PROGRESS TRACKING SYSTEM

Athletes who track body measurements, strength numbers, and nutrition data make progress 2–3× faster than those who "go by feel." Feelings are unreliable — data is not. A 0.5kg weight increase over 4 weeks feels like nothing but represents 24g of new muscle tissue (assuming stable body fat). Tracking makes these invisible gains visible and motivating.

Measure first thing in the morning, after toilet, before food or water. Use a flexible tape measure. Measure at the same anatomical landmarks each time. Take 3 measurements and average them to reduce error.

Measurement	Landmark	Week 1	Week 4	Week 8	Week 12	Change
Body weight (kg)	Morning fasted					
Chest (cm)	Nipple line, exhaled					
Waist (cm)	Narrowest point					
Hip (cm)	Widest point					
Upper arm L (cm)	Mid bicep, relaxed					
Upper arm R (cm)	Mid bicep, relaxed					
Thigh L (cm)	Mid quadricep					
Thigh R (cm)	Mid quadricep					
Calf L (cm)	Widest point					
Neck (cm)	Just below larynx					

Lift	Wk 1 (kg × reps)	Wk 4 (kg × reps)	Wk 8 (kg × reps)	Wk 12 (kg × reps)	% Gain
Back Squat					
Barbell Bench Press					
Conventional Deadlift					
Overhead Press					
Barbell Row					
Pull-ups (reps)					
Barbell Curl					
Leg Press					

SPORT-SPECIFIC & LIFESTYLE PROTOCOLS FOR INDIAN ATHLETES

The most common barrier to consistent training for Indian professionals aged 22–40 is time — specifically, the 10–12 hour workday combined with commuting, family obligations, and social commitments. The solution is not motivation; it is systematic scheduling. Training must be treated as a non-negotiable appointment with the same rigidity as a work meeting.

Scenario	Recommended Schedule	Session Duration	Notes
Office worker, 9–6 job	Train before work (6–7:30 AM) or after (7–8:30 PM)	60–70 min	Prepare kit night before
Shift worker / irregular hours	Train same time relative to sleep (3–4h after waking)	55–65 min	Circadian rhythm consistency
Business owner / self-employed	Mid-morning or early afternoon (10 AM–12 PM)	60–70 min	Protect this block proactively
Student (college/university)	Between classes or early morning	60 min	Use college gym to save travel
Home training (equipment limited)	3×/week full-body, 45–50 min	45–50 min	Prioritise compound movements

Indian culture involves 15–20 major festivals and social events per year where high-calorie, celebratory foods are unavoidable and expected. The physiologically correct approach is not restriction or guilt — it is strategic flexibility. One day of excess eating does not cause fat gain; it requires 3,500 kcal above maintenance to gain 0.5kg of fat. A typical festival meal of 3,000–4,000 kcal represents a surplus of 500–1,500 kcal — physiologically inconsequential if surrounded by normal eating.

- Festival strategy: Train the day before to maximise glycogen utilisation and insulin sensitivity.
 - Eat high protein before the feast to reduce total caloric intake.
 - Return to normal eating the day after — no "punishment" workouts or extended restriction.
 - View festival eating as a maintenance break (carb refeed), not a failure.
-
- Hotel room workout: Push-ups (6 variations), plank holds, single-leg squats, pike push-ups. Not ideal, but maintains neural patterns.
 - Find a local gym: Google Maps "gym near me" + city name. Daily drop-in rates across India: ■100–300.
 - Resistance bands: Full upper-body workout possible. Highly packable. Anchor to door hinges.
 - Maintain protein intake: Order grilled chicken/fish + dal/eggs at any Indian hotel. Avoid deep-fried items during travel.

■ **Missing 1–2 sessions during travel causes zero measurable muscle loss (atrophy begins after 2–3 weeks of complete inactivity). Travel anxiety about training is more harmful than the missed sessions.**

OPTIMISING HORMONAL HEALTH — THE NATURAL ATHLETE ROADMAP

Every serious natural athlete should get a blood panel done at least once per year — twice per year if actively trying to optimise hormonal health. Knowing your actual testosterone level, thyroid function, vitamin status, and haematology gives you real data to work with rather than guessing. The panel below costs approximately ₹2,500–4,000 at any Thyrocare or SRL Diagnostics lab in India.

Test	Normal Range	Why It Matters	What Low Means
Total Testosterone	300–1000 ng/dL (men)	Primary anabolic hormone	Low energy, poor recovery, reduced libido
Free Testosterone	9–30 ng/dL	Bioavailable T (most active)	Low despite normal total T → high SHBG
SHBG	10–57 nmol/L	Binds testosterone (reduces free T)	High SHBG → reduce alcohol, increase zinc
Vitamin D	40–80 ng/mL	Testosterone cofactor	Supplement 2000–5000 IU D3 daily
Zinc	70–120 mcg/dL	T synthesis cofactor, 300+ enzymes	Supplement 15–30mg zinc picolinate
TSH (Thyroid)	0.5–4.5 mIU/L	Metabolism regulator	Fatigue, weight gain, cold sensitivity
Haemoglobin	13.5–17.5 g/dL (men)	Oxygen delivery to muscles	Iron deficiency → poor endurance
HbA1c	<5.7%	Long-term blood sugar control	>6.5% = insulin resistance affecting gains
CRP (inflammation)	<1 mg/L	Systemic inflammation	Elevated → prioritise recovery & diet

Week	Action Items	Expected Impact
1–2	Start Vitamin D3 (4000 IU) + Zinc (25mg) + Magnesium glycinate (400mg) nightly	Foundational micronutrient support
1–4	Prioritise 7.5–9h sleep. No screens 60 min before bed. Blackout curtains	10–15% T from sleep optimisation alone
1–8	Compound training 4–5×/week. Squat + deadlift as foundation.	Increase androgen receptor density
1–12	Reduce body fat to 12–18% range (if currently higher)	Reduce aromatisation of T to oestrogen
2–12	Add Ashwagandha KSM-66 (600mg/day)	↓ Cortisol 28%, ↑ T 15–17% (12-week clinical trial)
4–12	Manage stress: 10 min pranayama or meditation daily	Reduce cortisol baseline, protect pregnenolone
12	Retest blood panel	Measure actual change in T, Vit D, Zinc

MINDSET, IDENTITY & LONG-TERM SUCCESS

The most reliable predictor of long-term fitness success is not motivation, willpower, or genetics — it is identity. When your behaviour is driven by "this is who I am" rather than "I should do this," consistency becomes effortless. The goal of this section is to accelerate that identity shift. Every action you take that aligns with being an athlete casts a vote for that identity. Each training session, each high-protein meal, each night of adequate sleep — these are identity votes. After 3–6 months of consistent votes, the identity solidifies.

- **Process > Outcome:** Focus on the inputs (training quality, protein hitting target, sleep hours) rather than the outputs (scale number, mirror appearance). Inputs are 100% within your control; outcomes have noise. Consistent inputs produce outcomes reliably over time.
- **Minimum Viable Session:** On low-energy days, commit to only 20 minutes. Most of the time, starting creates momentum and you complete the full session. If not — 20 minutes is still an identity vote. Never skip; scale down.
- **Data Over Feeling:** "I feel like I've gained fat" vs "my waist is 1cm smaller than 4 weeks ago." Feelings are real experiences but poor measurements. Track data. Feelings lie routinely; data does not.
- **Seasons, Not Sessions:** A single missed workout has zero physiological consequence. A single poor food choice has zero consequence. Zooming out to the 12-week, 12-month level removes the emotional weight of imperfect individual sessions.
- **Compare Backwards:** The only valid comparison is your past self. Comparing to others in the gym is a guaranteed path to either false confidence or unnecessary discouragement — both are useless. Your only competition is the version of you from 3 months ago.

■ *The Indian social environment can be particularly challenging — family pressure around food, peer scepticism about gym culture, festival obligations. Acknowledge these are real challenges, not excuses. Develop specific strategies for each challenge ahead of time rather than being caught unprepared.*

A plateau is not a failure; it is a signal. It tells you precisely two things: (1) your body has fully adapted to the current stimulus, and (2) a new challenge is required. The correct response is diagnosis, not panic or volume spam. Apply the checklist below in order before concluding you have hit a genuine plateau.

Check First	Question to Ask	If No → Action
Is progressive overload happening?	Weight/lifts/ reps increased in the last 3 weeks?	Add a small load increment even if uncomfortable
Is protein sufficient?	Are you consistently hitting 1.8g/kg/day?	Increase by 0.3g/kg and track for 2 weeks
Are you eating enough?	Is scale weight stable or rising on a bulk?	Increase calories by 200 kcal/day
Is sleep adequate?	Are you averaging 7.5+ hours across the week?	Prioritise sleep above all else for 2 weeks
Is there accumulated fatigue?	Do you feel strong and recovered on session 1 of the week?	Take a full deload week immediately
Is exercise selection optimal?	Are you training the muscle through full ROM?	Switch to an exercise with better ROM

ADVANCED NUTRITION — CARB CYCLING & REFEED STRATEGY

Carb cycling is the practice of strategically varying carbohydrate intake based on training demands — eating more carbohydrates on training days when muscles need glycogen, and fewer on rest days when the demand is lower. This approach maximises muscle glycogen on training days (better performance) while improving fat oxidation on rest days. It also helps manage insulin sensitivity and prevents the metabolic adaptation that occurs with sustained low-calorie dieting.

Day Type	Carb Target	Protein	Fat	Calorie Approx	Example Foods
Heavy training day	4–5g/kg	2.0g/kg	0.7g/kg	TDEE + 200–300	Rice, oats, banana, roti
Moderate training day	3–3.5g/kg	2.1g/kg	0.8g/kg	TDEE + 0–100	Rice, sweet potato
Light training day	2–2.5g/kg	2.2g/kg	1.0g/kg	TDEE – 150	Vegetables, small rice
Rest day	1.5–2g/kg	2.2g/kg	1.0–1.2g/kg	TDEE – 200–300	Vegetables, legumes

A refeed day involves temporarily eating at or slightly above maintenance calories — primarily through increased carbohydrates. Its primary purpose during a fat loss phase is to restore leptin levels (the satiety hormone that drops during sustained deficits), replenish glycogen for the following training sessions, and provide a psychological break from restriction. Refeeds are more valuable the leaner you become — implement every 7–14 days when body fat is below 12% (men) or 20% (women).

■ *Refeed foods for Indian athletes: 400–500g of white rice (or 8–10 rotis) distributed across the day with lean protein sources. Avoid high-fat refeed foods — you want insulin-mediated glycogen storage, not fat storage.*

SUPPLEMENTATION TIMING — COMPLETE DAILY PROTOCOL

Supplement	Morning	Pre-Workout	Post-Workout	Evening	Before Bed
Creatine (5g)	✓ (with water)	— (already saturated)	—	—	—
Whey protein (25g)	—	—	✓ (priority)	—	—
Caffeine (200mg)	—	✓ (45 min before)	—	—	■ (disrupts sleep)
Beta-alanine (1.6g)	—	✓ (split 2×1.6g)	—	✓ (second dose)	—
Citrulline (6g)	—	✓ (30–45 min before)	—	—	—
Vitamin D3 (4000 IU)	✓ (with fat meal)	—	—	—	—
Omega-3 (3g)	✓ (with food)	—	—	—	—
Zinc (25mg)	—	—	—	—	✓ (empty stomach)
Magnesium (400mg)	—	—	—	—	✓ (30 min before bed)
Ashwagandha (300mg)	—	—	—	—	✓ (with milk)

Introducing all supplements at once makes it impossible to identify what is working (or causing side effects).
Introduce one supplement per 2–3 weeks and monitor response before adding the next.

Month	Introduce	Rationale
Month 1	Creatine monohydrate (5g/day)	Biggest evidence base, immediate strength benefit
Month 2	Vitamin D3 (4000 IU) + Magnesium glycinate (400mg)	Fix near-universal deficiencies
Month 3	Whey protein (if dietary protein insufficient)	Convenient protein top-up post-workout
Month 4	Ashwagandha KSM-66 (600mg)	Cortisol management, T optimisation
Month 5	Omega-3 fish oil (3g EPA+DHA)	Inflammation, recovery, cardiovascular
Month 6	Citrulline malate (6g pre-workout)	Performance + pump enhancement

COMPLETE WEEKLY GROCERY GUIDE — MUSCLE BUILDING ON A BUDGET

Category	Items	Quantity (weekly)	Approx Cost (₹)	Protein Contribution
Protein — Animal	Chicken breast	700g	280–350	217g protein
Protein — Animal	Eggs	18 large	120–150	108g protein
Protein — Dairy	Paneer	300g	120–180	54g protein
Protein — Dairy	Greek dahi	1kg	100–150	70g protein
Protein — Plant	Soya chunks (dry)	300g	60–80	150g protein
Protein — Plant	Moong dal	500g	70–100	100g protein
Carbohydrates	White rice	2kg	100–140	—
Carbohydrates	Whole wheat flour (atta)	1kg	50–70	—
Carbohydrates	Oats (rolled)	500g	60–90	—
Carbohydrates	Banana	12	60–80	—
Fats	Desi ghee	200g	150–250	—
Fats	Almonds + walnuts	200g	200–300	—
Vegetables	Seasonal sabzi (spinach, broccoli, beans)	1.5kg	80–150	—
Supplements	Creatine (if needed)	35g	~50	+5g/day
	TOTAL		₹1,450–1,990	699g+ protein

■ This weekly grocery plan supports 2,800 kcal/day at ~200g protein for approximately ₹1,600–2,000. This is significantly less than most supplement budgets and produces superior results when executed consistently.

CONCLUSION — YOUR 12-WEEK ANABOLIC ROADMAP

You now have a complete, evidence-based system for building maximum muscle as an Indian athlete. Every element — training, nutrition, supplementation, recovery, mindset — has been designed for the Indian context: our foods, our schedules, our stress environment, and our cultural reality. The information in this guide is not generic Western bodybuilding advice repackaged. It is a system that can be implemented starting today, with the foods in your kitchen and the gym in your neighbourhood.

Day	Action	Time Required
Day 1	Take baseline measurements + photos. Log starting body weight.	15 min
Day 1	Calculate your TDEE on the RFC Beast Calculator. Set calorie + protein target.	10 min
Day 2	Complete Push Day A (Chapter 9). Log every set, rep, and weight.	65 min
Day 3	Complete Pull Day A. Focus on form over load.	70 min
Day 4	Complete Legs Day A. Film your squat from the side.	75 min
Day 5	Rest day: 30 min walk + foam rolling. Review grocery list from this guide.	45 min
Day 6	Complete Push Day B. Add ashwagandha and vitamin D to your morning routine.	65 min
Day 7	Complete Pull Day B. Review week 1 nutrition data. Adjust if protein target not met.	70 min

- Week 4: Take progress measurements and photos. Compare to baseline. Expect 0.3–0.5kg scale gain + noticeable strength increases.
- Week 8: Second check-in. Body composition should be visibly improved. Adjust calories if weight gain too fast (>0.5kg/wk for women, >0.7kg/wk for men).
- Week 12: Final photos, measurements, and lifts test. Record new PRs. Plan next cycle.

■ **Final Principle: Consistency over perfection. The athlete who trains 4 days a week for 5 years will always outperform the athlete who trains 6 days a week for 1 year and burns out. Build a sustainable practice first.**

ROYAL FITNESS CLUB — BUILD YOUR BEAST

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COMPLETE EXERCISE INDEX — 40 ESSENTIAL MOVEMENTS

Exercise	Primary Muscle	Equipment	Best Rep Range	Difficulty
Barbell Bench Press	Pectoralis major (mid)	Barbell + bench	5–12	Intermediate
Incline DB Press	Pectoralis major (upper)	DB + incline bench	8–15	Intermediate
Decline Bench Press	Pectoralis major (lower)	Barbell + decline bench	8–12	Intermediate
Cable Crossover (low)	Pec major (upper)	Cable machine	12–20	Beginner
Cable Crossover (high)	Pec major (lower)	Cable machine	12–20	Beginner
Push-ups	Pec major + triceps	Bodyweight	15–30	Beginner
Dips (chest)	Pec major + triceps	Parallel bars	8–15	Intermediate
DB Pullover	Pec major + serratus	DB + flat bench	12–15	Intermediate

Exercise	Primary Muscle	Equipment	Best Rep Range	Difficulty
Pull-ups (pronated)	Latissimus dorsi (width)	Pull-up bar	5–12	Intermediate
Chin-ups (supinated)	Lats + biceps	Pull-up bar	6–12	Beginner-Int
Lat Pulldown	Latissimus dorsi	Cable + bar	8–15	Beginner
Barbell Row (bent-over)	Mid back + lats	Barbell	5–10	Intermediate
T-Bar Row	Mid back thickness	T-bar	6–12	Intermediate
Seated Cable Row	Mid + lower back	Cable machine	8–15	Beginner
Single-Arm DB Row	Lats + mid back	DB + bench	8–12	Beginner
Face Pull (rope)	Rear delts + rotator cuff	Cable	15–20	Beginner
Straight-Arm Pulldown	Latissimus dorsi isolation	Cable	12–20	Beginner

Exercise	Primary Muscle	Equipment	Best Rep Range	Difficulty
Barbell OHP	Anterior + medial delts	Barbell	4–10	Intermediate
DB Arnold Press	All 3 delt heads	Dumbbells	8–15	Intermediate
DB Lateral Raise	Medial deltoid	Dumbbells	12–20	Beginner
Cable Lateral Raise	Medial deltoid	Cable	12–20	Beginner
Rear Delt Fly (cable)	Posterior deltoid	Cable	15–20	Beginner
Upright Row	Medial delts + traps	Barbell / cable	8–15	Beginner

Exercise	Primary Muscle	Equipment	Best Rep Range	Difficulty
Barbell Curl	Biceps brachii	Barbell / EZ bar	8–15	Beginner
Incline DB Curl	Biceps (lengthened)	DB + incline bench	10–15	Beginner
Hammer Curl	Brachialis + brachioradialis	Dumbbells	10–15	Beginner
Concentration Curl	Biceps peak isolation	Dumbbell	12–15	Beginner
Tricep Pushdown (rope)	Triceps (all heads)	Cable	12–20	Beginner
Skull Crusher (EZ bar)	Triceps long head	EZ bar	8–12	Intermediate
Close-Grip Bench Press	Triceps + chest	Barbell	6–12	Intermediate
Overhead Tricep Extension	Triceps long head	DB / cable	10–15	Beginner

Exercise	Primary Muscle	Equipment	Best Rep Range	Difficulty
Back Squat	Quads, glutes, hamstrings	Barbell + rack	5–12	Intermediate
Romanian Deadlift	Hamstrings + glutes	Barbell / DB	8–12	Intermediate
Leg Press	Quads, glutes	Leg press machine	10–20	Beginner
Bulgarian Split Squat	Quads + glutes	DB / barbell	8–12/leg	Intermediate
Hip Thrust (barbell)	Gluteus maximus	Barbell + bench	8–15	Beginner
Leg Curl (lying/seated)	Hamstrings	Machine	10–15	Beginner
Walking Lunges	Quads + glutes	DB / barbell	12–20 steps	Beginner
Standing Calf Raise	Gastrocnemius	Machine / free	15–25	Beginner
Seated Calf Raise	Soleus	Machine	15–25	Beginner

COMPLETE 7-DAY MEAL PLAN — NON-VEGETARIAN (2,800 KCAL/DAY)

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast 7:30 AM	4 eggs scrambled + 2 roti + dahi 150g + green tea	36g P / 40g C / 18g F
Mid-Morning 10:30 AM	Banana + 20 almonds + 200ml milk	12g P / 38g C / 12g F
Lunch 1:00 PM	150g chicken breast + 200g rice + dal + sabzi	46g P / 74g C / 10g F
Pre-Workout 4:30 PM	80g oats + 1 banana + 25g whey	32g P / 60g C / 5g F
Post-Workout 7:00 PM	150g chicken + 180g rice + salad	44g P / 64g C / 8g F
Dinner 9:30 PM	100g paneer + 2 roti + sabzi	26g P / 30g C / 14g F

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast 7:30 AM	3 eggs + 2 egg whites + 2 roti + dahi	34g P / 36g C / 14g F
Mid-Morning 10:30 AM	Apple + cottage cheese 100g + 10 walnuts	16g P / 28g C / 14g F
Lunch 1:00 PM	150g fish (rohu/pomfret) + 200g rice + sabzi	38g P / 72g C / 10g F
Pre-Workout 4:30 PM	100g oats + milk 200ml + 1 banana	24g P / 65g C / 8g F
Post-Workout 7:00 PM	150g chicken + 180g rice + curd	44g P / 68g C / 8g F
Dinner 9:30 PM	200g moong dal + 2 roti + sabzi	24g P / 50g C / 6g F

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast 7:30 AM	4 eggs whole + 2 roti + milk 200ml	34g P / 38g C / 18g F
Mid-Morning 10:30 AM	Dahi 200g + banana + 15 almonds	16g P / 35g C / 10g F
Lunch 1:00 PM	200g chicken + 200g rice + sabzi + dal	52g P / 74g C / 10g F
Pre-Workout 4:30 PM	Banana + 30g whey protein	26g P / 28g C / 2g F
Post-Workout 7:30 PM	200g rice + 150g chicken + salad	44g P / 72g C / 8g F
Dinner 9:30 PM	100g paneer + 1.5 roti + sabzi + curd	24g P / 26g C / 14g F

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast 8:00 AM	3 eggs + 1.5 roti + green vegetables	24g P / 28g C / 14g F
Lunch 1:00 PM	150g chicken + 150g rice + dal	38g P / 56g C / 8g F

Evening 5:00 PM	Dahi 150g + cucumber + handful nuts	12g P / 12g C / 10g F
Dinner 8:00 PM	150g fish + sabzi + 1 roti + salad	32g P / 20g C / 8g F
Pre-sleep 10 PM	200ml warm milk + small handful almonds	10g P / 12g C / 10g F

Total Thursday (rest day): ~2,300 kcal | 116g P | 128g C | 50g F

FRIDAY / SATURDAY / SUNDAY follow the same pattern as Mon/Tue/Wed

Adjust rice/roti quantities to hit your specific calorie target. Every 100g cooked rice = 130 kcal / 28g carbs.
Every medium roti = 90 kcal / 18g carbs.

COMPLETE 7-DAY MEAL PLAN — VEGETARIAN (2,600 KCAL/DAY)

Meal	Time	Foods	P	C	F	kcal
Breakfast	7:30 AM	Paneer bhurji (150g) + 2 roti + dahi 150g	34g	36g	20g	462
Mid-Morning	10:30 AM	Soya chunks (40g dry) + milk 200ml	28g	30g	6g	290
Lunch	1:00 PM	Moong dal 200g + 200g rice + sabzi	26g	76g	6g	470
Pre-Workout	4:30 PM	Oats 80g + whey 25g + banana	30g	60g	5g	405
Post-Workout	7:00 PM	Paneer 100g + 200g rice + curd 150g	28g	68g	14g	506
Dinner	9:30 PM	Chana dal 200g + 1.5 roti + sabzi	22g	50g	8g	364

Daily Total: ~2,497 kcal | 168g P | 320g C | 59g F — adjust rice for exact target

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast	3 eggs + 1 roti + dahi + green tea	20g P / 22g C / 12g F
Lunch	Paneer 100g + dal + small bowl rice + sabzi	28g P / 40g C / 14g F
Evening	Greek dahi 200g + fruits + nuts	16g P / 25g C / 10g F
Dinner	Soya chunks + sabzi + 1 roti + curd	24g P / 28g C / 8g F

INDIA SUPPLEMENT GUIDE — TRUSTED BRANDS & WHERE TO BUY

Brand	Product	Price Range	Notes	Where to Buy
MuscleBlaze	Whey Gold / Raw Whey	■1,500–3,500/kg	Most popular in India, 3rd party tested	Amazon, Flipkart, local stores
Optimum Nutrition	Gold Standard Whey	■3,500–6,000/kg	Global gold standard, excellent mixability	Amazon, ON India website
MyFitFuel	100% Whey Protein	■1,800–3,000/kg	Indian brand, good value	Amazon, MFF website
Nakpro	Whey Concentrate	■1,200–1,800/kg	Budget option, decent quality	Amazon, Big Basket
Dymatize	ISO100 Hydrolysate	■4,000–7,000/kg	Premium hydrolysed whey, fast absorption	Amazon, specialty stores

Brand	Product	Price	Notes
MuscleBlaze	Creatine Monohydrate	■400–600/500g	Micronised, excellent value
Nakpro	Creatine	■350–500/500g	Budget pick, same molecule as premium brands
Optimum Nutrition	Micronised Creatine	■800–1,200/300g	Premium but not necessary vs MuscleBlaze
Healthkart HK Vitals	Creatine Monohydrate	■350–500/250g	Widely available offline

Supplement	Recommended Brand	Price	Notes
Vitamin D3	HealthKart, NOW Foods, Carbamide Forte	■150–400	Get D3 (cholecalciferol) not D2. 2000–5000 IU dose.
Magnesium	NOW Foods Magnesium Glycinate, Himalayan Organics	■400–700	Glycinate form = best absorption, no laxative effect
Zinc	Carbamide Forte, HealthKart	■200–400	Picolinate or bisglycinate form. 15–25mg elemental zinc.
Omega-3	NOW Foods Fish Oil, MuscleBlaze Fish Oil	■400–800	Check EPA+DHA per serving, not just total fish oil
Ashwagandha	KSM-66 (Ixoreal), Himalaya, MuscleBlaze	■250–600	Look for KSM-66 or Sensoril extract on label

■ **Warning:** Counterfeit supplements are common in India. Always buy from Amazon, Flipkart, or brand websites. Avoid gym stall purchases without receipts. Check lot numbers on brand websites.

BODY COMPOSITION MEASUREMENT — METHODS COMPARED

Body fat percentage is the single most important body composition metric — more useful than scale weight alone. A person can gain muscle while losing fat, with the scale not moving, yet transform their physique dramatically. Several measurement methods are available in India at different price points.

Method	Accuracy	Cost	Availability	Best For
US Navy Formula (tape measure)	±3–5%	Free	Anyone with tape	Baseline + ongoing tracking
Skinfold calipers	±3–4%	■300–500 (caliper)	Gym / self-measure	Weekly tracking
DEXA Scan	±1–2%	■2,500–5,000/scan	Major cities (Thyrocare, hospitals)	Accurate baseline, bi-annual
Bioelectrical Impedance (BIA)	±4–8%	Free (most gym machines)	Any gym	Directional, not precision
Hydrostatic weighing	±1–2%	■1,000–2,000	Limited to research labs	Research purposes
RFCs Beast Calculator (Navy Formula)	±3–5%	Free	Website, instant	Regular tracking — recommended

Category	Men	Women	Visual Description
Essential fat	3–5%	10–13%	Dangerous if below — organ and hormone protection only
Athletic	6–13%	14–20%	Visible abs, muscle separation clearly visible
Fitness	14–17%	21–24%	Lean, athletic look; some muscle definition
Average	18–24%	25–31%	Healthy range; some softness, no visible abs
Obese	>25%	>32%	Health risks increase; prioritise fat loss first

■ Target range for optimal anabolic environment in men: 10–16% body fat. Below 8% or above 22%, testosterone production is compromised. Women: 16–24% for optimal hormonal health.

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ROYAL FITNESS CLUB — COMPLETE ANABOLIC SYSTEM

All content is for educational purposes. Consult a medical professional before beginning any programme.

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TRAINING SPLITS — COMPREHENSIVE COMPARISON GUIDE

The training split — how you divide muscle groups across the training week — is one of the most debated topics in fitness. The reality: the "best" split is the one you can execute consistently with adequate volume, intensity, and recovery. The table below compares the five most common splits used by Indian gym athletes.

Split	Days/Week	Who It's For	Weekly Volume/Muscle	Key Advantage	Key Limitation
Full Body	3	Beginners, time-limited	6–9 sets	High frequency, fast learning	Low per-session volume
Upper/Lower	4	Intermediates 1–2 yr	8–12 sets	Good frequency + volume balance	Less specialisation
Push/Pull/Legs (PPL)	5–6	Intermediates 1.5–3 yr	10–18 sets	High volume per muscle	Requires 5–6 days commitment
Bio Split (1 muscle/day)	5	Any level	10–20 sets	High per-session focus	Low frequency (1×/week/muscle)
Arnold Split (2×/week)	6	Advanced 3+ years	14–22 sets	High frequency + high volume	Very demanding, recovery critical

Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest	Day A or B
Barbell/Goblet Squat	4	10	2 min	Both days
Barbell/DB Bench Press	3	10	90s	Both days
Romanian Deadlift	3	10	2 min	Both days
Lat Pulldown or Pull-ups	3	10	90s	Both days
Seated DB OHP	3	10	90s	Both days
Barbell Curl	2	12	60s	Day A
Tricep Pushdown	2	12	60s	Day B
Plank	3	30–60s hold	45s	Both days

Day	Focus	Key Movements
Monday — Upper A	Strength focus (heavy)	Bench press 4×5, Row 4×5, OHP 3×6, Pulldown 3×8
Tuesday — Lower A	Quad dominant	Squat 4×6, Leg press 3×10, RDL 3×10, Calf raise 4×15
Thursday — Upper B	Hypertrophy focus	Incline DB 4×10, Cable row 4×12, Laterals 5×15, Arms
Friday — Lower B	Posterior chain	RDL 4×8, Hip thrust 4×12, Leg curl 4×12, Lunges 3×12

■ **Progression Principle for All Splits:** Track every set and aim to beat last session's numbers by at least 1 rep or 2.5kg every 1–2 weeks on compound movements.

POSTURE CORRECTION & STRUCTURAL BALANCE

Poor posture is epidemic among Indian office workers and students — hours of desk work and phone usage create predictable muscular imbalances that directly impair training performance and increase injury risk. The most common pattern: tight hip flexors + weak glutes + tight chest + weak upper back + forward head posture. This pattern compresses lumbar vertebrae, internally rotates the shoulders, and reduces training ROM on every major compound movement.

Postural Problem	Tight/Overactive Muscles	Weak/Underactive Muscles	Corrective Exercises
Forward head posture	SCM, upper traps, pec minor	Deep cervical flexors, lower traps	Chin tucks, face pulls, thoracic extension
Rounded shoulders	Pec major/minor, anterior deltoids	Rhomboids, mid/lower traps, rotator cuff	Band pull-aparts, Y-T-W, face pulls 3×20 daily
Anterior pelvic tilt	Hip flexors, lumbar erectors	Glutes, abs, hamstrings	Glute bridges, dead bugs, hip flexor stretches
Knee valgus (caving)	Adductors, TFL	Glute medius, VMO	Clamshells, lateral band walks, single-leg press
Flat feet / overpronation	Calf complex, peroneals	Tibialis posterior, foot intrinsics	Single-leg calf raises, toe spreads, barefoot walking

Exercise	Sets × Reps/Duration	Corrects	Notes
Thoracic extension over foam roller	1 × 60 sec	Rounded upper back	Vertebrae T4–T10, each segment
Hip flexor stretch (kneeling)	3 × 45 sec/side	Anterior pelvic tilt	Squeeze glute of rear leg
Dead bug	3 × 10 reps/side	Core/APT	Maintain lumbar contact with floor
Band pull-aparts	3 × 20 reps	Rounded shoulders	Shoulder-width grip, pull to chest
Glute bridge	3 × 15 reps	Glute activation/APT	Pause 2 seconds at top
Face pull (band)	3 × 15 reps	Forward head + rounded shoulders	External rotate at end position
World's Greatest Stretch	1 × 5/side	Full body mobility	Hip flexor + thoracic + hamstring

WEEKLY MEAL PREP GUIDE — SAVE TIME, STAY ON TRACK

The single biggest reason Indian athletes miss their protein target is not lack of willpower — it is that high-protein foods require preparation time that is not available on a busy weekday. Meal prepping 2 hours on Sunday eliminates this problem for 5 days. Research shows people who meal prep eat significantly more protein, fewer processed foods, and hit their calorie targets more consistently.

Time	Task	Output	Serves
0:00–0:30	Marinate and cook 1kg chicken breast (oven/air fryer/tawa)	700g cooked chicken	5–6 meals
0:00–0:20	Cook 2 cups moong dal	4–5 portions dal	4–5 meals
0:20–0:50	Cook large batch white rice (electric cooker)	8–10 portions rice	4–5 meals
0:30–0:60	Boil 12 eggs	12 boiled eggs	4 days breakfasts
0:40–1:00	Chop all vegetables (onion, tomato, capsicum, cucumber)	Pre-chopped veg	All week sabzi
1:00–1:20	Cook 2 different sabzis for variety	8 portions vegetables	4 days
1:20–1:40	Portion into containers with macros label	10–12 meal containers	5 work days
1:40–2:00	Prepare overnight oats for 3 mornings	3 breakfasts	Mon/Wed/Fri

Food	Fridge Life	Freezer Life	Best Container
Cooked chicken	4 days	3 months	Airtight glass or BPA-free plastic
Cooked rice	4–5 days	1 month	Airtight container, spread flat to cool
Dal (cooked)	4–5 days	2 months	Glass jar or container
Boiled eggs	1 week (in shell)	Not recommended	Egg tray / bowl, unpeeled
Chopped vegetables	3–4 days	Not recommended	Airtight container, paper towel layer
Overnight oats	3–4 days	Not recommended	Mason jars or sealed bowls

■ **Investment: 2 hours on Sunday = 10 hours saved during the week. Every meal that's already made and measured removes a decision that could result in a fast-food compromise. Meal prep is the infrastructure of consistent nutrition.**

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Note
Mon	Overnight oats + eggs	Prepped chicken + rice + sabzi	Fresh paneer/dal + roti	
Tue	Eggs + leftover dal	Prepped chicken + rice	Prepped dal + sabzi + roti	
Wed	Overnight oats + eggs	Prepped chicken + rice + sabzi	Fresh sabzi + eggs + roti	

Thu	Eggs + dahi	Remaining chicken + rice	Dal + sabzi + roti	Rest day — reduce rice
Fri	Overnight oats	Last prepped chicken + rice	Fresh cook or dine out smartly	End of batch
Sat–Sun	Fresh cook	Fresh cook	Fresh cook	Enjoy variety

TROUBLESHOOTING GUIDE — SOLVE THE 15 MOST COMMON PROBLEMS

Problem	Most Likely Cause	Solution
Not gaining weight on bulk	Underestimating calories eaten (Track food with MyFitnessPal for 7 days — most people undercount by 20–30%)	
Not losing fat on deficit	Same — underestimating intake, especially fats	Weigh all food with kitchen scale for 2 weeks
Strength not improving	Insufficient sleep, insufficient calories, or no progressive overload	Check sleep (7.5h+), increase food by 200 kcal, add 2.5kg to bar
Constantly sore muscles	Volume too high, insufficient sleep/protein	Reduce sets by 30%, eat more protein, sleep 8h
Shoulder pain on bench	Elbows flared too wide	Tuck elbows to 45–60°, reduce weight, add face pulls
Lower back pain on deadlift	Rounding lower back / too heavy	Reduce weight, film from side, focus on bracing
No gym motivation	Lack of a compelling goal	Write specific goal (e.g. "bench 100kg by March"), display it
Plateau (no size gain 4+ weeks)	Training stimulus stagnated	Change rep ranges, add advanced technique, increase volume
Fat gain while bulking	Calorie surplus too large	Reduce surplus to 200–250 kcal; weigh daily, weekly average
Poor recovery between sessions	Insufficient sleep or food	Eat more on training days; sleep 8h minimum
Can't hit protein target	Not planning meals with protein sources	Meal prep (see previous section); add a protein shake if needed
Gym intimidation	Unfamiliarity with equipment and culture	Start 6 AM when gym is quiet; follow written program, not guesswork
Joint pain (general)	Accumulated stress without deload	Take a deload week immediately; add joint nutrition protocol
Feeling weak during workout	Insufficient pre-workout nutrition or sleep	Eat 40–60g carbs 60–90 min before training
Bloating / digestive issues	Sudden high-protein diet or new supplements	Decrease protein gradually; try digestive enzymes; stay hydrated

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Every answer you need is in this guide. Execute consistently. Results are inevitable.

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QUICK REFERENCE CARD — NUMBERS EVERY ATHLETE MUST KNOW

Metric	Formula / Value	Notes
Daily Protein	1.8–2.2g × body weight (kg)	Minimum to build/maintain muscle
Daily Calories (bulk)	TDEE + 250–350 kcal	~0.25–0.5kg/week gain target
Daily Calories (cut)	TDEE – 350–500 kcal	~0.5–0.75kg/week loss target
Water intake	35–40ml × body weight (kg)	Add 500ml per 1h training
Protein per meal	≥ 30–40g (≥3g leucine)	Minimum to trigger mTOR
Weekly sets per muscle	10–20 hard sets	Below 10 = insufficient, above 25 = diminishing returns
Sleep duration	7.5–9 hours	60–70% daily GH released during sleep
Rest between heavy sets	2–3 minutes	For compound lifts, strength focus
Rest between isolation	60–90 seconds	For accessory work, metabolic focus
BMI healthy range	18.5–24.9 kg/m²	For general population; athletes may be higher
Body fat — athletic male	6–13%	Visible abs, muscle definition
Body fat — athletic female	14–20%	Lean, athletic physique
Progressive overload rate	2.5–5kg/2 weeks (beginner)	0.5–2.5kg/2 weeks (intermediate)
Deload frequency	Every 4–8 weeks	After every training block
Creatine dose	5g/day, any time	No loading phase needed
Vitamin D3	2000–5000 IU/day	With a fatty meal for absorption